

IronVault User Manual

For macOS 13 Ventura and later · October 9, 2026

IronVault seals every file in your vault on its own, so no app or AI tool can read one unless you approve that exact file with Touch ID. This manual covers macOS 13 Ventura and later. The screens are illustrations drawn from the app's current design, not screenshots.

At a glance

Each file is encrypted on its own, and only one file opens per approval. A file goes through these stages:

- 1. **Sealed.** You drop it into the IronVault folder in your home folder, or use Add Files to Vault. It becomes `name.ext.ivaunt` and the plain original is deleted. Sealing never asks for Touch ID.
- 2. **Asked for.** You double-click the sealed file, or another app or AI tool asks IronVault to open it.
- 3. **Approved.** macOS shows a prompt naming that exact file. Touch ID or your password approves it; Cancel refuses it.
- 4. **Open.** A decrypted copy opens in its usual app (Preview, Word, Pages). Every save is sealed back into the vault file.
- 5. **Wiped.** The copy is deleted 15 minutes after you open it or last save it, when you choose Close and Wipe, when the Mac sleeps or locks, or when you quit IronVault.

An app that reads a sealed file directly gets only encrypted data, and the Dashboard records the attempt.

Part	Where it lives	What it does
IronVault app	Lock icon in the menu bar	Opens files after Touch ID, saves edits back, wipes copies
Vault folder	<code>~/IronVault</code>	Holds your sealed <code>.ivaunt</code> files
Watchdog	Runs every 15 seconds in the background	Wipes copies if the app isn't running, seals plain files left in the folder
<code>ironvault</code> command	<code>/Library/IronVault/bin/ironvault</code>	Seals, lists and recovers files from Terminal
Dashboard	Menu bar > Dashboard...	Shows who asked to open what, and reads IronVault noticed

Before you install

You need a Mac with Touch ID (or your login password), macOS 13 Ventura or later, and about five minutes. You don't need Xcode.

- ☐ Quit every AI app, agent and coding tool.
- ☐ Turn on FileVault in System Settings > Privacy & Security > FileVault.
- ☐ Install Apple's free Command Line Tools: run `xcode-select --install` in Terminal and wait for it to finish. If it says they're already installed, you're set.
- ☐ Unzip `ironvault.zip` somewhere outside iCloud Drive, such as your Downloads folder.

Install and save your recovery key

The installer builds IronVault on your Mac, creates your vault key, and shows your recovery key once.

1. Open Terminal and run `zsh ~/Downloads/ironvault/install.sh`.
2. Approve the Touch ID or password prompts. There are a few.
3. When the yellow recovery key appears, save it in your password manager or on paper. It is the only way to open your files if this Mac is lost, because the key is kept out of backups on purpose.
4. Press Return. The window clears so the key doesn't stay on screen.

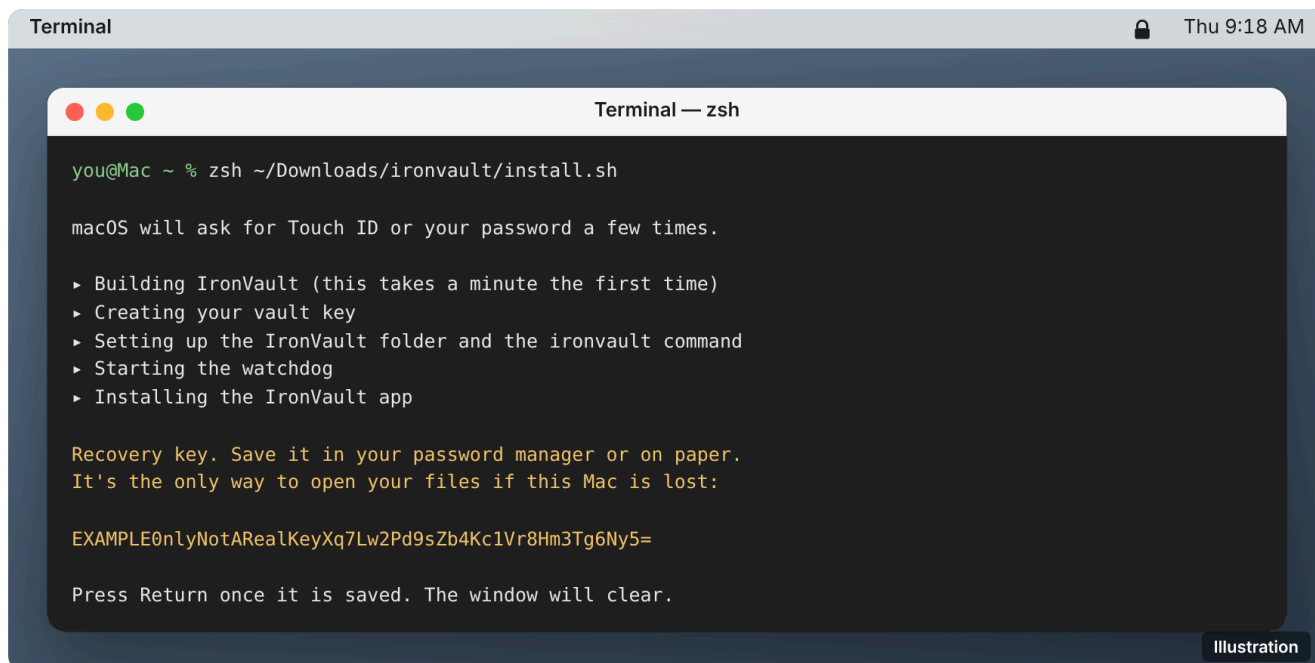


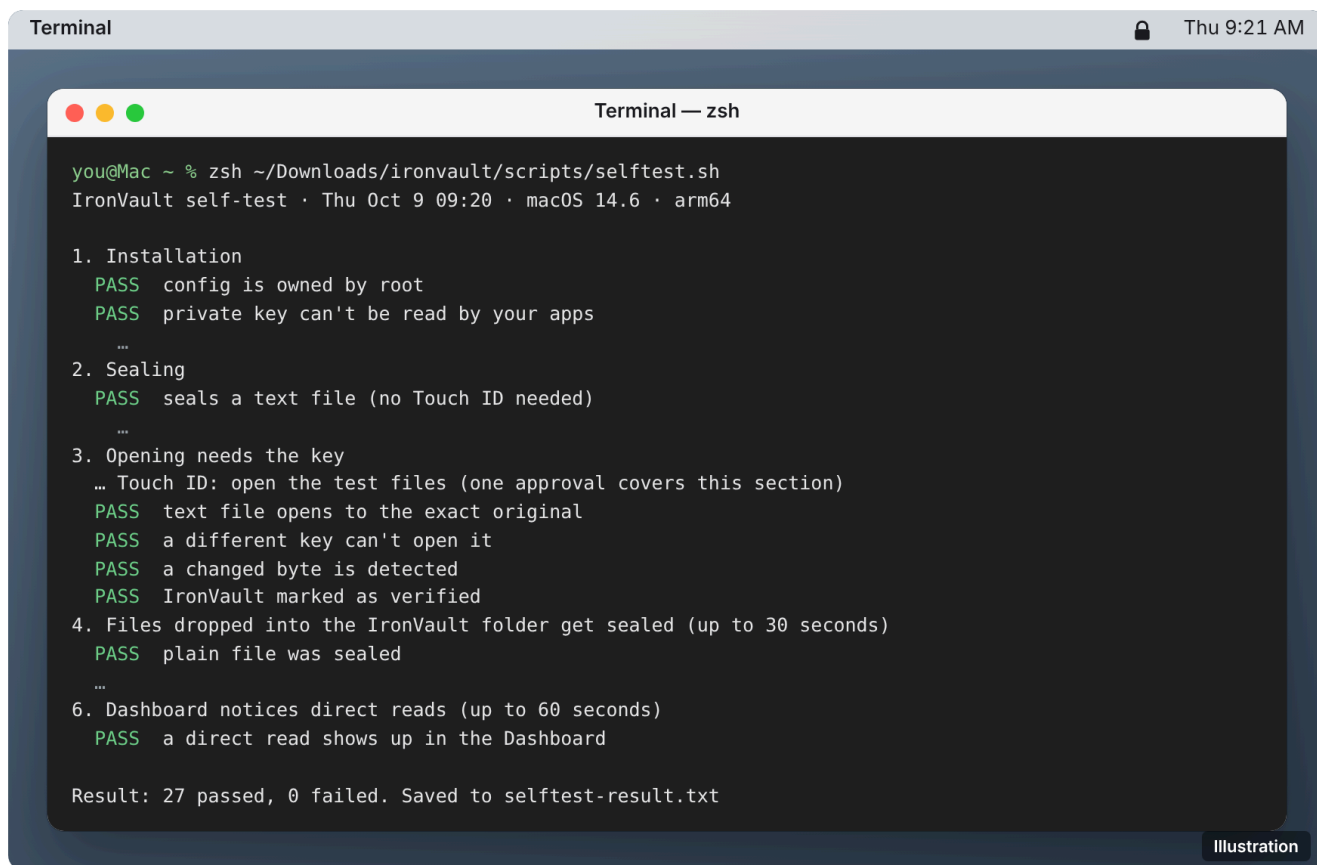
Illustration. The key shown is an example; yours is different.

macOS may say IronVault added a background item. That's the watchdog, so leave it on. If the build fails, see Troubleshooting.

Run the self-test

The self-test proves sealing and opening work on your Mac, and until it passes IronVault never deletes an original. Folder auto-sealing stays off, Add Files keeps your originals, and the menu shows “Run the self-test to finish setup.”

1. Run `zsh ~/Downloads/ironvault/scripts/selftest.sh`.
2. Approve Touch ID once, when section 3 opens the test files.
3. Wait for the result line. Some sections wait up to 60 seconds for the watchdog.

A screenshot of a macOS Terminal window titled "Terminal — zsh". The window shows the execution of the script `~/Downloads/ironvault/scripts/selftest.sh`. The output displays a series of checks grouped into sections. Section 1 (Installation) shows "PASS" for config ownership and private key accessibility. Section 2 (Sealing) shows "PASS" for sealing a text file. Section 3 (Opening needs the key) shows "PASS" for opening the test files, with a note about Touch ID approval. Section 4 (Files dropped into the IronVault folder get sealed) shows "PASS" for sealing a plain file. Section 6 (Dashboard notices direct reads) shows "PASS" for a direct read. The final result line states: "Result: 27 passed, 0 failed. Saved to selftest-result.txt". The terminal window has a dark background and standard macOS window controls. A small "Illustration" label is visible in the bottom right corner of the terminal window frame.

```
you@Mac ~ % zsh ~/Downloads/ironvault/scripts/selftest.sh
IronVault self-test · Thu Oct 9 09:20 · macOS 14.6 · arm64

1. Installation
  PASS config is owned by root
  PASS private key can't be read by your apps
  ...
2. Sealing
  PASS seals a text file (no Touch ID needed)
  ...
3. Opening needs the key
  ... Touch ID: open the test files (one approval covers this section)
  PASS text file opens to the exact original
  PASS a different key can't open it
  PASS a changed byte is detected
  PASS IronVault marked as verified
4. Files dropped into the IronVault folder get sealed (up to 30 seconds)
  PASS plain file was sealed
  ...
6. Dashboard notices direct reads (up to 60 seconds)
  PASS a direct read shows up in the Dashboard

Result: 27 passed, 0 failed. Saved to selftest-result.txt
```

Illustration, shortened. A full run has 27 checks in six sections.

The result is saved to `selftest-result.txt`. If any check fails, send that file. Section 7 then lists checks to try by hand: open a file, cancel a prompt, edit and reopen, look at the Dashboard, and lock the screen with a document open.

Add files to the vault

The easiest way is to drop files into the **IronVault** folder in your home folder. Within about 10 seconds each one becomes a sealed `.ivault` file and the plain original is deleted.

From anywhere else, choose **Add Files to Vault...** in the menu bar, pick files or folders, then choose what happens to the originals:

Button	Result
Seal and Delete Originals	Only the sealed copies remain.
Seal and Keep Originals	Sealed copies are added and your originals stay where they were.
Cancel	Nothing changes.

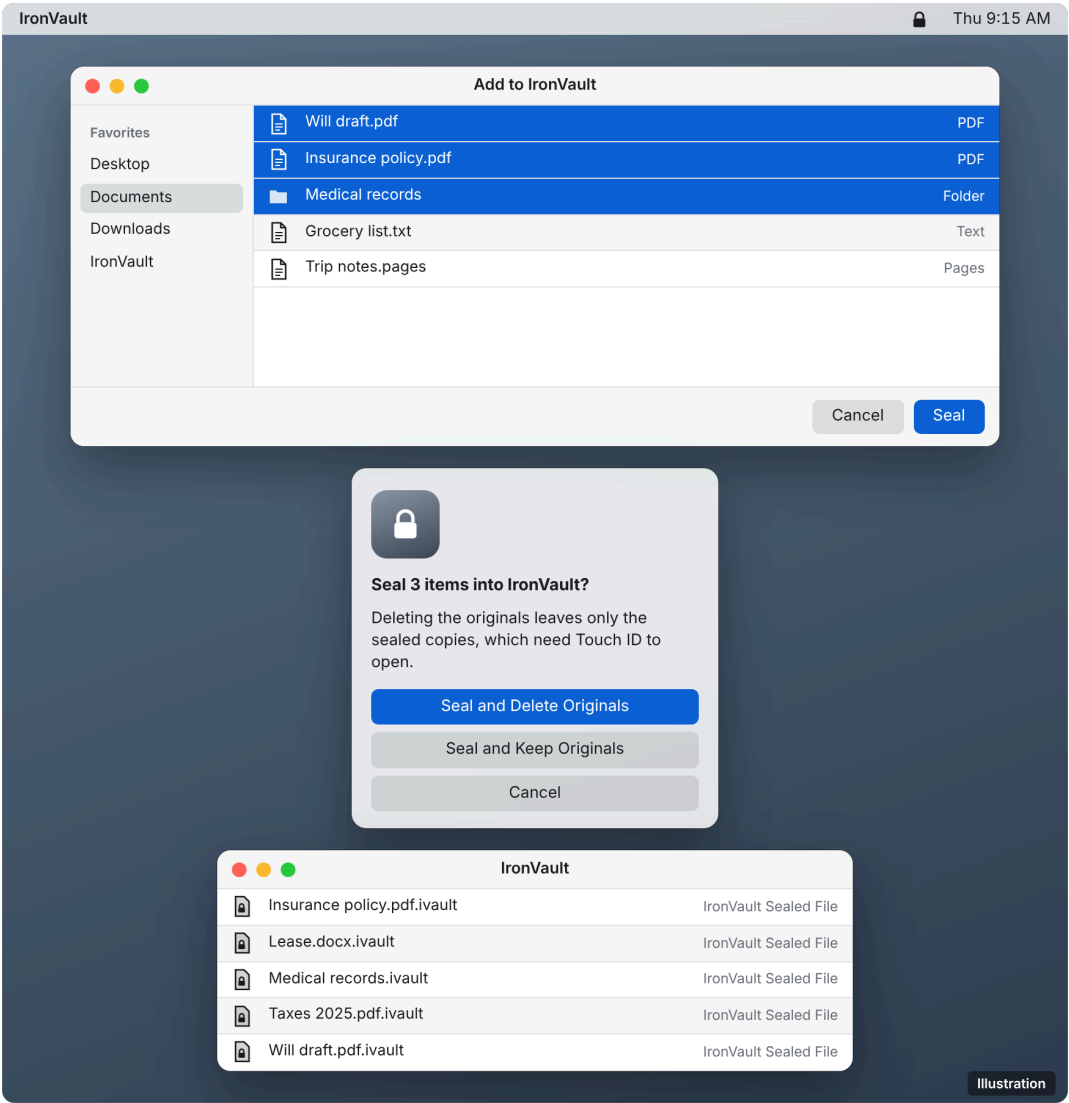


Illustration with example file names.

Folders and packages (such as Pages documents) are sealed as one file. Each file can be up to 2 GB. Adding files never asks for Touch ID.

Open a file with Touch ID

Double-click any `.ivault` file in Finder, or choose **Open a Vault File...** in the menu bar. macOS shows its administrator prompt with IronVault's message naming the file. Approve, and only that document opens in its usual app.

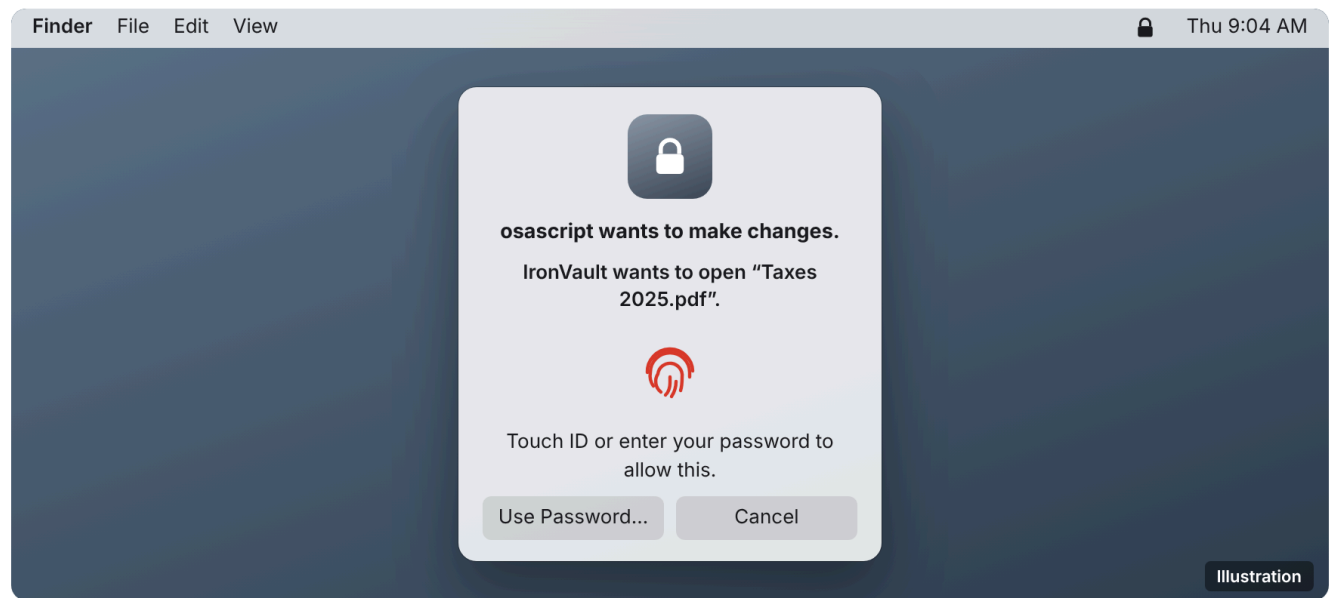


Illustration.

- **Approve** with Touch ID or your password: the document opens, and the menu bar lock shows it as open.
- **Cancel**: nothing opens. The Dashboard records the refusal and which program asked.
- **Several files at once** share one prompt, such as "IronVault wants to open 3 documents: ...".

The prompt's title says "osascript". That's the macOS tool IronVault uses to show it; check that the message under it names IronVault and a file you chose. If an AI tool or another app asks IronVault to open a file, you see the same prompt. Only approve prompts you started.

Edit, save and close

Work in the document as usual. Each time you save, IronVault seals the change back into the vault file within a second or two, and the closing countdown restarts at 15 minutes.

When	What happens to the open copy
15 minutes after you open it or last save it	Saved back, then wiped
You choose Close and Wipe, or Close All Documents	Saved back, then wiped
The Mac sleeps, the screen locks, or you switch users	Saved back, then wiped (if that setting is on)

When	What happens to the open copy
You quit IronVault, or log out or shut down	Saved back, then wiped
The app crashes or is force-quit	Wiped by the watchdog within about 15 seconds
8 hours after opening, however much you extend it	Wiped by the watchdog

To keep working past the countdown, choose the document in the menu bar, then **Keep Open 15 More Minutes**. Close the document in its own app before IronVault wipes the copy, or that app may complain the file is gone. If saving back ever fails, the copy is kept and the menu shows why, so an edit is never lost silently.

The menu bar

IronVault lives in the menu bar and has no Dock icon. The lock is closed when nothing is open, open while a document is decrypted, and shows a warning badge when the Dashboard has new alerts.

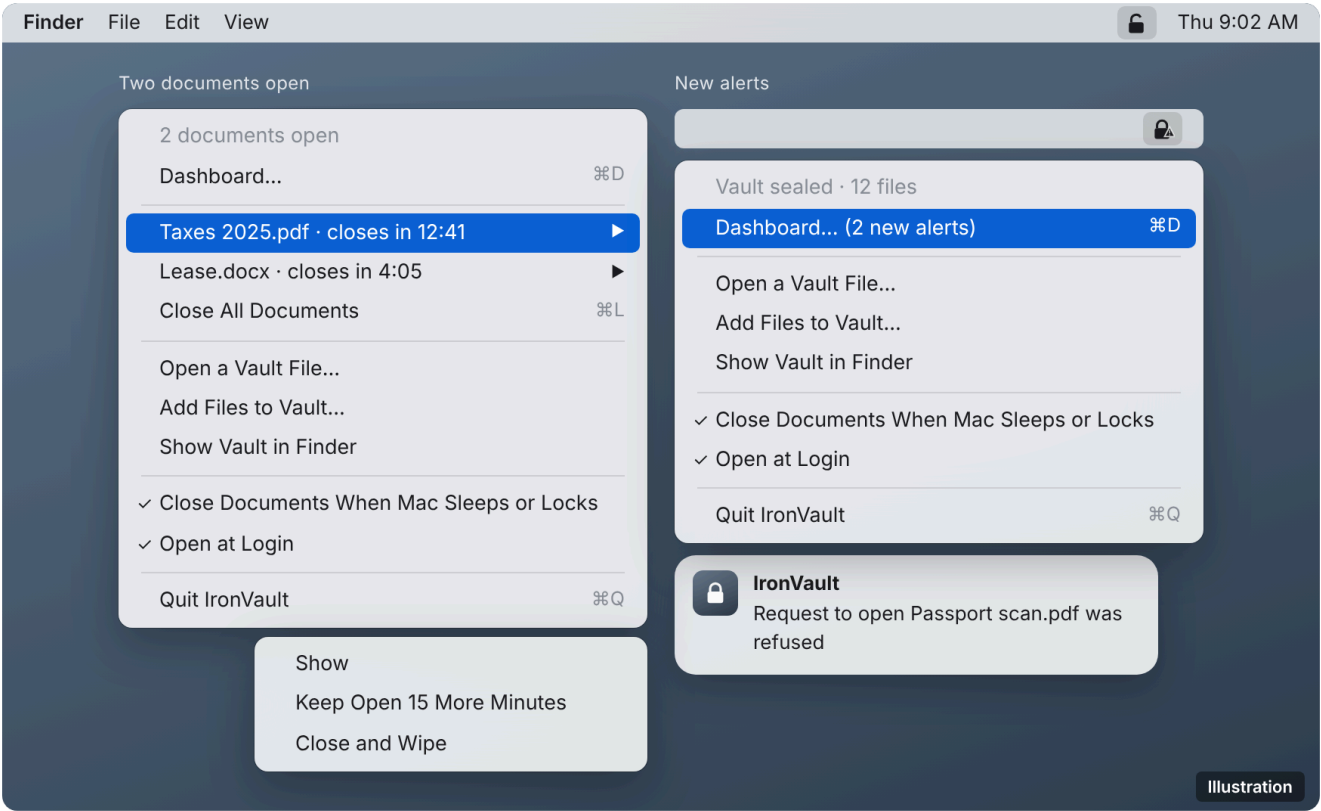


Illustration with example files.

Item	What it does
Status line	Shows how many files are sealed, or how many documents are open

Item	What it does
Dashboard... (⌘D)	Opens the Dashboard; shows the count of new alerts
<i>document</i> > Show	Brings an open document to the front
<i>document</i> > Keep Open 15 More Minutes	Delays the wipe, up to 8 hours in total
<i>document</i> > Close and Wipe	Saves changes into the vault, then deletes the decrypted copy
Close All Documents (⌘L)	The same for everything open
Open a Vault File...	Pick sealed files to open; one Touch ID covers files picked together
Add Files to Vault...	Seal files or folders, then delete or keep the originals
Show Vault in Finder	Opens your IronVault folder
Close Documents When Mac Sleeps or Locks	On by default
Open at Login	On by default
Quit IronVault (⌘Q)	Saves and wipes every open document, then quits

The Dashboard

The Dashboard shows every request to open a vault file, your answer, which program asked, and the reads IronVault could detect. Choose **Dashboard...** in the menu bar. When something new needs your attention, the lock shows a warning badge and you get a notification.

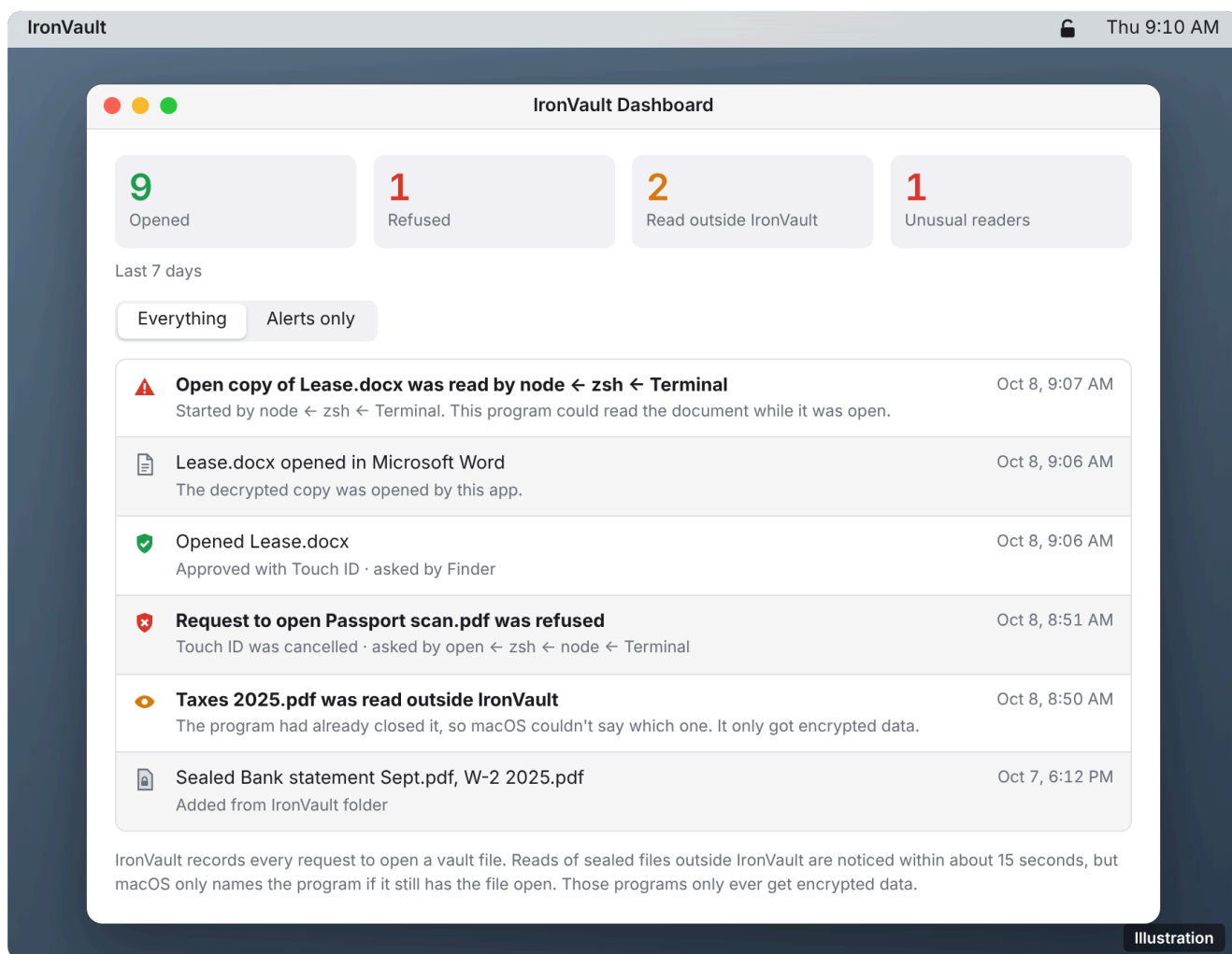


Illustration with example events.

The four counts at the top cover the last 7 days. Choose **Alerts only** to hide routine entries. Alerts are shown in bold.

Entry	What it means	Alert?
Opened <i>file</i>	You approved with Touch ID. Shows who asked: Finder for a double-click, or a chain such as <code>open ← zsh ← node ← Terminal</code>	No, since you approved it
Request to open <i>file</i> was refused	Something asked and Touch ID was cancelled	Yes
<i>file</i> was read outside IronVault	A program read the sealed file directly. It only got encrypted data	Yes
<i>file</i> opened in <i>app</i>	The document's own app opened the decrypted copy	No
Open copy of <i>file</i> was read by <i>program</i>	A command-line tool or AI app read the decrypted copy while it was open	Yes

Entry	What it means	Alert?
Sealed <i>files</i>	Files were added to the vault	No

Limits. Direct reads are noticed within about 15 seconds, but macOS names the program only if it still has the file open; quick reads show as unknown. Open copies are checked every 5 seconds, so a faster read can be missed. Time Machine reads during backups aren't listed, and antivirus scans may show as unknown reads.

The record is kept in `~/Library/Application Support/IronVault/activity.log` and also in macOS's system log, which apps can't erase. To see it there:

```
log show --last 7d --predicate 'subsystem == "local.ironmountain.ironvault"'
```

The ironvault command

The `ironvault` command lives in `/Library/IronVault/bin`. It can seal files but can't open them; only the app can, after Touch ID.

Command	What it does
<code>ironvault add FILE...</code>	Seals files into the vault and deletes the originals; works only after the self-test passes
<code>ironvault add --keep FILE...</code>	Seals files and keeps the originals
<code>ironvault open FILE.ivault</code>	Asks the app to open a file, which shows the Touch ID prompt
<code>ironvault list</code>	Lists sealed files
<code>ironvault status</code>	Shows the vault folder, file count, open documents and self-test state
<code>ironvault sweep</code>	Seals any plain files left in the vault folder now
<code>ironvault recover FILE [FOLDER]</code>	Opens a file with your recovery key, without the app

Recovery, updating and uninstalling

Update. Run `install.sh` from a newer copy. It keeps your key and files, replaces the rest, and asks you to run the self-test again before originals are deleted.

Open a file without the app (a new Mac, or the key file is lost). Install IronVault on any Mac, then run the line below and type your recovery key when asked:

```
/Library/IronVault/bin/ironvault recover ~/IronVault/"Taxes 2025.pdf.ivault" ~/Desktop
```

Move your key to a new Mac so double-click works again. Do this before installing, so the installer keeps your key instead of making a new one:

```
sudo mkdir -p /Library/IronVault/key && sudo chmod 700 /Library/IronVault/key
read -rs "?Recovery key: " K; printf '%s' "$K" | sudo tee /Library/IronVault/key/private.key
>/dev/null; unset K
sudo chmod 400 /Library/IronVault/key/private.key && sudo chown -R root:wheel /Library/IronV
ault
zsh ~/Downloads/ironvault/install.sh
```

Uninstall. Run `zsh ~/Downloads/ironvault/uninstall.sh`. It removes the app, watchdog, command, key and login item, and leaves your sealed files in `~/IronVault`. After that, only your recovery key opens them.

What is protected and what isn't

A sealed file can't be read by any app running as you, AI tools included; opening it takes your fingerprint or password, file by file. These limits apply to any tool of this kind:

- **An open document is readable.** While a file is open, any app on your Mac can read its decrypted copy, as the document's own app does. Only that file is exposed, and only until it's wiped.
- **Apps keep their own copies.** Autosaves, version history, Office autorecovery, Quick Look thumbnails and Recent Items are outside IronVault's reach.
- **Apps that can see your screen** (Screen Recording or Accessibility access) can see an open document. Review them in System Settings > Privacy & Security.
- **Approving is permission.** Approving a prompt you didn't start, or giving an AI tool your password, opens the file.
- **File names are visible.** Contents are sealed, but a name like `Taxes 2025.pdf.ivault` can be seen.
- **Sealed files can be deleted.** Apps can't read them but could delete them, so keep `~/IronVault` in Time Machine; the backups stay sealed.
- **Files up to 2 GB.**

Optionally, ask AI tools to stay out. For Claude Code, add this to `~/claude/settings.json`. It's a rule the tool follows, not a lock.

```
{
  "permissions": {
    "deny": [
      "Read(~/.IronVault/**)",
      "Read(~/.Library/Caches/IronVault/**)",
      "Read(/Library/IronVault/**)"
    ]
  }
}
```

Troubleshooting

Problem	Fix
The install says the build failed	Reinstall the Command Line Tools: <code>sudo rm -rf /Library/Developer/CommandLineTools</code> , then <code>xcode-select --install</code> , then run <code>install.sh</code> again. With Xcode installed too, also run <code>sudo xcode-select --switch /Library/Developer/CommandLineTools</code>
The menu says "Run the self-test to finish setup."	Run <code>scripts/selftest.sh</code> . Until it passes, originals are never deleted
The menu says IronVault isn't installed	Run <code>install.sh</code> again
A self-test check failed	Send <code>selftest-result.txt</code> . Nothing is deleted until every check passes
Files dropped in the folder aren't sealed	The self-test hasn't passed yet, or the app and watchdog aren't running. Run <code>ironvault status</code>
The prompt shows only a password field	Your Mac has no Touch ID set up for this; the password does the same job
A document closed while I was working	The countdown ran out or the Mac locked. Your last save is in the vault; reopen it and use Keep Open 15 More Minutes
"Couldn't save changes" in the menu	The open copy is kept. Free disk space, then save again or choose Close and Wipe
The Dashboard shows an unknown read	A program read a sealed file and closed it quickly. It got only encrypted data. Antivirus scans often cause this

Problem	Fix
IronVault doesn't start at login	Turn on Open at Login in the menu, and check System Settings > General > Login Items
A file is lost after a new Mac or a reinstall	Use <code>ironvault recover</code> with your recovery key (see Recovery)